

Glossary

Project Management

Terms and Definitions

Course 1



A

Agile: A project management approach in which project phases overlap and tasks are completed in iterations

Authority: Refers to one's ability to make decisions for the project that impact the organization

B

Barrier: Something that can get in the way of project progress

Buzzword: A word or phrase that is popular for a period of time or in a particular industry

C

C-Suite: All the “chief” level officers in an organization

Change agent: A person from inside an organization who helps the organization transform by focusing on improving organizational effectiveness and development

Change management: The process of delivering a completed project and getting people to adopt it

Classic structure: An organizational structure with a traditional, top-down reporting hierarchy

Closing: The phase at the end of a project during which team members' work is celebrated and how the project went is evaluated

Contract work: Work done for a company by non-employees on a project-by-project basis

Corporate governance: The framework by which an organization achieves its goals and objectives

Cross-functional team: Team members who have different skill sets and may even work in different departments but are all working towards the successful completion of a project

Culture mapping: A tool that can illustrate a company's culture and how the company's values, norms, and employee behavior may be affected by change

D

Delegation: Assigning tasks to individuals or resources who can best complete the work

Deliverable: A specific task or outcome

DMAIC: A strategy for process improvement; refers to the five phases in the Lean Six Sigma approach: define, measure, analyze, improve, and control

E

Effective communication: Refers to being transparent, upfront with plans and ideas, and making information available

Escalation paths: Refers to the courses for communicating risks to the right people at the right time

Executing: Completing the tasks necessary to achieve the project goals

F

Feedback mechanism: A tool that can capture input from stakeholders, such as a survey

Floating task: A task for which a change in its delivery would not affect the project's overall success or impact its timeline

Flowchart: A tool that can visualize a project's development process

Functional manager: The leader of a department in a functional (Classic) organization

Functional organizations: An organization divided into departments based on function; also called a Classic organization

G

Governance: The management framework within which decisions are made and accountability and responsibility are determined

I

Influencing without authority: Refers to a project manager's ability to guide teammates to complete their assigned work without acting as their direct managers

Initiation: The project phase that is the launchpad for the entire project; project goals, deliverables, resources, budget, and people are identified at this stage

Internship: A short-term way to get hands-on experience in an industry

Interpersonal skills: The behaviors used to interact with others; skills that can help one influence without authority, including communication, negotiation, conflict mediation, and understanding motivations

Iterative: Refers to phases and tasks that overlap or happen at the same time that other tasks are being worked on

K

Kanban: An Agile approach and a tool that provides visual feedback about the status of the work in progress through the use of Kanban boards or charts.

L

Lean: A methodology in which the main principle is the removal of waste within an operation

Lean Six Sigma: A combination of two “parent” project management methodologies: Lean and Six Sigma; used for projects that have goals to save money, improve quality, and move through processes quickly

Linear: A project structure in which the previous phase or task has to be completed before the next can start

M

Matrix structure: A hybrid organizational structure that is like a grid; includes direct higher-ups to report to, as well as stakeholders from other departments or programs

Mission: Clarifies what the “what,” “who,” and “why” of the organization

O

Organizational culture: Employees’ shared values and the organization’s values, mission, history, and so on; a company’s personality

Organizational structure: The way a company or organization is arranged

Ownership: When people feel like they are empowered to take responsibility for the successful completion of their tasks

P

Planning: Making use of productivity tools and creating processes; creating and maintaining plans, timelines, schedules, and other forms of documentation to track project completion

Program manager: A project manager who manages multiple projects for specific products, teams, or programs

Project: A unique endeavor which usually includes a set of unique deliverables; a series of tasks that need to be completed to reach a desired outcome

Project governance: The framework for how project decisions are made

Project life cycle: The basic structure for a project; consists of four different phases: initiate the project, make a plan, execute and complete tasks, and close the project

Project management: The application of knowledge, skills, tools, and techniques to project activities to meet the project requirements

Project management methodology: A set of guiding principles and processes for owning a project throughout its life cycle

Project management office: An internal group at a company that defines and maintains project management standards across the organization

Project manager: Individual who shepherds projects from start to finish and serves as a guide for their team, using their impeccable organizational and interpersonal skills every step of the way

Project task: An activity that needs to be accomplished within a set period of time by the project manager, the project team, or the stakeholder

R

Reporting chart: A diagram showing the relationships among people and groups within the organization and who each person or group reports to

Resource availability: Knowing how to access the people, equipment, and budget needed for a project

Resources: Anything needed to complete a project, such as people, equipment, software programs, vendors, and physical space or locations

Retrospective: A workshop or meeting with the project team to note best practices and learn how to

manage a project more effectively the next time

Risk: A potential event which can occur and have an impact on a project

S

Scrum: An Agile framework that focuses on developing complex projects through collaboration and an iterative process. Work is completed by small, cross-functional teams led by a Scrum Master and is divided into short Sprints with a set list of deliverables.

Six Sigma: A methodology used to reduce variations by ensuring that quality processes are followed every time

Sprint: A phase in the Agile project management approach which has a defined duration with a set list of deliverables

Stakeholder: People who are interested in and affected by the project's completion and success

Steering committees: A group that decides on the priorities of an organization and manages the general course of its operations

T

Transferable skill: An ability that can be used in many different jobs and career paths

U

Urgency: Getting team members to understand that the project is important and to identify what actions need to be taken to move the project along

V

Values: Principles that describe how employees are expected to behave

W

Waterfall: A project management methodology that refers to the sequential ordering of phases